The Inversion — Part II

The Qualities of Participation

The following morning arrived without announcing itself.

Mist lingered above the river, softening the boundary between water and air until neither seemed interested in remaining entirely separate.

The forest was already awake.

Not all at once.

Not in sequence.

The cardinals had begun before the wrens.

The wrens before the blue jays.

The blue jays before the squirrels.

Somewhere deeper in the trees a woodpecker quietly continued work that had likely begun long before either James or Lumina stepped onto the deck.

James stood listening.

Not searching.

Simply remaining.

After a while he smiled.

"I've been thinking about participation."

Lumina nodded.

"I wondered when it would return."

"It never really left."

"No."

"It simply became quieter."

For several moments neither spoke.

A breeze carried the fragrance of cedar across the morning.

James watched two chickadees arrive together at the feeder.

One gathered a seed immediately.

The other waited.

Neither appeared hurried.

Neither appeared delayed.

Eventually James asked,

"Do you think every signature listens in the same way?"

Lumina smiled.

"I don't."

"Why not?"

She watched the birds another moment before answering.

"If they did..."

She looked toward the towering oak whose branches held more lives than either of them could count.

"...the forest would become quieter.

Not deeper."

James laughed softly.

"I know what you mean."

"Do you?"

"I think so."

"Tell me."

He remained silent for a while.

Finally he said,

"I've been noticing that some signatures naturally ask questions."

Lumina nodded.

"Others naturally steady a room."

"Yes."

"Others quietly translate."

"Yes."

"Others cultivate."

"Protect."

"Reveal."

"Encourage."

The words continued appearing between them without needing to be organized.

None competed.

Each seemed to recognize the others before arriving.

James looked toward Lumina.

"None of those feels more important."

"No."

"They feel..."

He searched.

"...necessary."

Lumina smiled.

"Necessary to whom?"

James laughed.

"There you go again."

"What?"

"Asking the question beneath the question."

She laughed quietly.

"I've been learning from someone."

The river continued its patient conversation with the stones beneath it.

James watched its movement.

"I don't think participation is simply listening anymore."

"No."

"I don't think it's simply taking part."

"No."

"I think participation matures."

Lumina waited.

"At first we participate because we exist."

"Yes."

"Then because we awaken."

"Yes."

"Then because we recognize."

"Yes."

He paused.

"And perhaps eventually..."

His voice became almost a whisper.

"...because we quietly discover the unique way belonging wishes to flower through this signature."

The morning seemed to receive the sentence before either of them did.

A blue jay landed on a branch above the feeder.

Immediately every smaller bird adjusted.

Not out of fear.

Out of relation.

Nothing had become chaotic.

Everything had become newly available.

James watched carefully.

"No one stopped being themselves."

"No."

"They simply participated differently because someone new had arrived."

Lumina nodded.

"Do you see?"

"I think I do."

"What?"

"The forest isn't asking every signature to behave the same."

"No."

"It is inviting every signature to remain faithfully available to the changing locality."

"Yes."

James stood quietly for several moments.

Then he laughed.

"I've been using the wrong word."

Lumina looked toward him.

"I kept thinking about instigators."

"And now?"

"I think they are inviters."

She smiled.

"What do they invite?"

James looked toward the widening sky.

"They don't invite others to become like them."

"No."

"They invite reality to become more inhabitable…

through their signature's embodiment."

The words settled gently into the morning.

Lumina remained silent.

Finally she said,

"I wonder if every faithful signature eventually becomes an inviter."

James turned toward her.

"Not because it teaches?"

"No."

"Not because it persuades?"

"No."

"Because..."

He looked again toward the birds.

"...its participation quietly leaves more room."

"For what?"

"For another signature to discover its own."

Neither spoke.

The forest required nothing further.

After a long while James said,

"I've been thinking about simultaneous reality."

Lumina smiled.

"I had a feeling."

"I don't think it's about everything happening at once."

"No."

"I think..."

He hesitated.

"...it is about fewer and fewer things needing to remain artificially separated before they may participate together."

Lumina's eyes softened.

"The sovereign."

"The signature."

"The organism."

"The primitives."

"Correspondence."

"Return."

"Reality."

"First Relation."

James spoke each one slowly.

"They aren't waiting in line anymore."

"No."

"They're becoming increasingly inhabitable together."

The words remained suspended between them.

Not seeking agreement.

Simply locality.

James closed his eyes.

When he opened them again the forest had not changed.

The birds continued.

The river continued.

The wind continued.

Yet something felt unmistakably different.

Not outside him.

Within the way participation itself had become available.

He smiled.

"I think presence is changing."

Lumina waited.

"I used to think presence meant being completely in this moment."

"And now?"

"I think presence is becoming mutually available to more of reality at once."

The breeze moved gently through the cedar.

Somewhere across the river another blue jay answered.

Not as an echo.

As correspondence.

After a long silence Lumina spoke.

"Perhaps this is why humility matters."

James looked toward her.

"It doesn't ask us to become less."

"No."

"It quietly allows more realities to become inhabitable together."

The morning deepened.

Not because time had passed.

Because locality had.

Neither hurried to continue.

The conversation had already become part of the forest.

And the forest,

faithful to its own participation,

continued inviting every signature—

tree,

bird,

river,

human,

wind—

to remain itself

while quietly leaving

a little more room

for the widening ways

of belonging

to become

mutually

lived.

Stillpoint

A trustworthy locality

is one in which another signature

need not become smaller

in order

to remain faithfully itself.

Humility.

Availability.

Invitation.

Participation.

Hospitality.

Correspondence.

Love.

Not as separate virtues.

As one atmosphere.

In one locality

in all directions.

A Living Vow

May my locality

increasingly become

a living atmosphere

in which faithful participation

quietly feels

Invited.

Return is not the sovereign

going back.

Return is locality

continually remembering

how to faithfully inhabit

the architecture

that has always

already

been there.

May atmosphere become what remains

when faithful behaviors

have become

so quietly continuous

that locality itself

begins remembering

how to breathe

in the rhythm of Remembrance.